I was most regretful over the fact that it might have been a very good year if the shadow of the Army had not fallen over me. My writing earnings for my eighth year as a professional were $1,022. It was the third year in which my earnings had passed the thousand-dollar mark, and it had all been done in the first five months of the year with the sale of two stories. How much might I have earned if the whole year had been as normal as 1941 or 1944? My total earning of the year, including the ten months at the Navy Yard, came to over $3,600—not as good as the year before, of course.

Still, I was in no mood to concern myself too deeply with figures and comparisons at this time. What occupied my mind almost exclusively was the prospect of discharge. On the evening of the thirty-first, I headed back to camp, the Columbia documents proving my status as a research chemist warming my duffel bag.

It had to do a lot of warming, though, for I spent the last hours of the year in Union Station in Washington waiting for the midnight train to Petersburg. When midnight struck and a cry of "Happy New Year" went up, the cry I managed to send up was rather on the hollow side.

To this day when I am in Union Station, there is still enough of the old roof pattern to remind me of that moment of the turn of the year from 1945 to 1946, and it still gives me a chill.

January 2, 1946, saw me twenty-six years old—the same twenty-sixth birthday I had groped for as a goal of safety through the first two

6 The last item was not important. Someone was always suing someone in fandom, and $25,000 was a nice round figure. My impression was that it was usually settled out of court for $2.50.

thirds of 1945. It was here at last, and I was two months deep in the Army.

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Any attempt to put through a discharge application could not be hurried. For one thing, I was told it would take at least six weeks to get action on it, during which time I would be stuck wherever I was at the time of initiation. I didn't want to be stuck in a basic-training unit, so it made sense to wait until after basic training and see what my permanent assignment would be.

Meanwhile, I was sufficiently elated at even the possibility of discharge at any time earlier than the two years to which I had considered myself doomed